



The Mindful Bloom Journal

For Binge Eating & Overeating Recovery

A guided journal of education, coping tools, and reflection





Welcome

This journal was created to sit alongside your recovery from binge eating or overeating — part workbook, part quiet space to think on paper. Each section pairs a short piece of education with tools you can actually use in the moment, and prompts for noticing the emotions and situations that shape your relationship with food.

There is no correct way to fill these pages. Skip what doesn't fit, return to what helps, and write in whatever order your week calls for.

Before you begin: This journal is an educational and reflective companion — it is not therapy, medical care, or a substitute for treatment. It won't ask you to track calories, weigh food, or hit any numeric target — the goal is understanding your patterns and building skills, not more rules around food. Please use it alongside support from a doctor, therapist, and/or registered dietitian who knows your full history. If you notice this journal bringing up distress rather than relief, that's worth mentioning to your care team, not pushing through alone.

How this journal is organized

- **Understanding the pattern** — brief, plain-language education
- **Your toolbox** — coping skills to practice before you need them
- **Daily check-ins** — short, repeatable pages for ongoing use
- **Weekly reflection** — a wider-lens look at the week
- **Values & resources** — what you're working toward, and where to find support





Understanding the Pattern

A little education can take the shame out of a very common experience.

Binge eating disorder and chronic overeating are recognized, treatable conditions — not a personal failing or a lack of willpower. Research consistently points to cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) and dialectical behavior therapy (DBT) as the most strongly evidence-based treatments, both of which work by building awareness of triggers and new ways to respond to difficult emotions.

The cycle many people recognize

- A triggering emotion, thought, or situation arises (stress, loneliness, boredom, criticism, a rigid rule broken)
- Eating becomes a way to soothe, numb, or distract from that internal state
- During the episode there can be a sense of losing control or eating on "autopilot"
- Afterward, guilt or shame shows up — which itself can become the next trigger

Naming this cycle is not about blame. It's about finding the earliest possible point — usually the triggering emotion — where a different response becomes possible.

Common triggers to watch for

- Restriction earlier in the day (skipped meals, very rigid "rules")
- Stress, overwhelm, or exhaustion
- Loneliness, boredom, or a low mood
- Conflict or criticism, including self-criticism
- Certain times of day, places, or being alone





Your Toolbox

Skills to practice on an ordinary day, so they're ready on a hard one.

Eating with Ease

A slower, more present way to move through a meal — practice this on purpose, not just when things feel hard.

1. Put food on a plate.
2. Take three deep breaths before eating.
3. Put your utensil down while chewing. If eating something that doesn't require a utensil, put the food down between bites.
4. Stretch your meal out to take at least 15–20 minutes by taking breaks, getting up and walking away for a minute, or just stopping for another three deep breaths.
5. Chew food 25 times before swallowing.
6. When you start to feel satiated (a warm feeling in your body, your stomach feeling slightly full), eat three more bites. Eat only the foods you truly want. If you start to feel deprived (since you may be eating less than usual), tell yourself "less is best!" Use this mantra any time you want to stop earlier but have difficulty. The truth is less IS best. Remind yourself — especially if you're enjoying your food — that you'll have more to look forward to again. There is plenty of food available. This is only one meal!
7. Practice having the feeling of slimness in your body. Make a "visceral picture" of feeling light, strong, and lean. Sit up and stand up tall — it will make you feel thinner. Stretch — it will nourish your body. Move your body in ways that feel good. Be kind to it, and it will be kinder to you!

HALT check

Before responding to an urge to eat, pause and ask: am I Hungry, Angry, Lonely, or Tired? Naming the actual need underneath an urge — rest, connection, comfort — opens up more ways to meet it.

Urge surfing

Urges rise, peak, and fall like a wave, usually within minutes, whether or not you act on them. Instead of fighting the urge, try observing it: where do you feel it in your body? What does it feel like right now, and does that change if you just watch it for a few minutes without judging it?

The delay-and-check-in technique

When an urge hits, commit to waiting a short, specific amount of time before acting on it — even five or ten minutes. Use the pause to check in with HALT, take a few slow breaths, or step into another room. You can always choose to eat afterward; the delay just creates room to choose rather than react.

Opposite action (DBT)

If shame is pulling you toward isolating or restricting after an eating episode, opposite action means gently doing the reverse of what the urge suggests — reaching out to someone, or eating your next regular meal as planned rather than skipping it in "compensation." This interrupts the guilt-restriction-binge cycle at its root.



5-4-3-2-1 grounding

Name 5 things you can see, 4 you can hear, 3 you can touch, 2 you can smell, and 1 you can taste. This brings an anxious or dissociated mind back into the present moment, which is often the first step out of autopilot eating.

Self-compassion break

Try three lines, in your own words: "This is a moment of struggle. Struggling with food is part of a shared human experience, not a personal defect. May I be kind to myself right now." Shame tends to fuel the next episode; self-compassion has been shown to help break that cycle instead.





Thought record (CBT)

Use this any time a food-related thought feels loud or absolute ("I've already ruined today," "I have no self-control"). Writing it down creates distance from it.

Situation

Automatic thought

Emotion & intensity (0–10)

Evidence for / against the thought

A more balanced thought

SEEDS balance check

Sleep, Eating (regular meals — not restricting), Exercise, Downtime, Socializing. When one of these is badly out of balance, urges tend to intensify. Circle the one most out of balance this week, and name one small way to tend to it.





Daily Check-In

A short page for an ordinary day — use as many copies as you like.

Date

How is my HALT right now? (Hungry / Angry / Lonely / Tired)

What emotion showed up around food today, and what was happening just before it?

What did I need in that moment — and what tool did I reach for (or could I try next time)?

One thing I want to acknowledge myself for today, unrelated to food or body:





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Weekly Reflection

Zoom out from single days to notice the wider pattern.

What situations, places, or times of day were hardest for me this week?

Which tool from my toolbox did I actually reach for — and how did it go?

Where did I notice guilt or shame after eating? What would I say to a friend in that moment?

What's one pattern I'm starting to notice about my triggers?

What's one small thing I want to try differently next week?





Values & Motivation

Recovery is easier to keep choosing when it's anchored to something bigger than any single meal or moment. Use this page to reconnect with your "why."

Beyond food and weight, what kind of life am I working toward?

What has this eating pattern cost me, that I'd like to reclaim?

Who or what motivates me to keep going, even on hard days?

What would "a good relationship with food" actually look and feel like for me?





Support & Resources

Recovery isn't meant to happen in isolation. Keep this page bookmarked.

National Alliance for Eating Disorders Helpline Free, professionally-staffed support and referrals to treatment

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline

Call or text 988 (US) for 24/7 crisis support

Crisis Text Line

Text HOME to 741741 (US/Canada) for 24/7 text support

Your treatment team

Doctor, therapist, and/or registered dietitian — write their contact info below

My care team

A closing thought

Healing rarely moves in a straight line, and a hard day with food is information, not a verdict on your worth or your progress. Be as gentle with yourself on the page as you'd be with someone you love.

